Coins

- Coins of Satavahanas
- Coins of Kadphises II
- Roman coins

Literary Sources

- *Puranas*
- *Gargi Samhita*
- *Harshacharita* of Banabhatta
- *Mahabhasya* of Patanjali
- *Brihastkatha* of Gunadhya
- *Madhyamika Sutra* of Nagarjuna
- *Buddhacharita* of Asvaghosha
- *Malavikagnimitra* of Kalidasa

Foreign Notice

- Accounts of Hiuen Tsang, the Chinese Buddhist monk and traveller

The Sungas and Kanvas in the North

The Sungas

The last Mauryan emperor, Brihadratha, was assassinated by his own general, Pushyamitra Sunga, who established his Sunga dynasty in Magadha. Pushyamitra made Pataliputra as his capital.

Pushyamitra's kingdom extended westward to include Ujjain and Vidisha. He successfully repulsed the invasion of Bactria king, Menander. But Menander managed to keep Kabul and Sindh.

Pushyamitra thwarted an attack from the Kalinga king Kharavela. He also conquered Vidarba. He was a staunch follower of Vedic religion. He performed two Asvamedha yagnas (horse sacrifices) to assert his imperial authority.

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During the Sunga period, stone was replaced by wood in the railings and the gateways of the Buddhist *stupas* as seen in Bharhut and Sanchi.

Pushyamitra was succeeded by his son Agnimitra. This Agnimitra is said to be the hero of Kalidasa's *Malavikagnimitra*. The drama also refers to the victory of Vasumitra, Agnimitra's son, over the Greeks on the banks of the Sindhu river.

The weak successors of Sungas constantly faced threats from the Indo-Bactrians and Indo-Parthians. The Sunga dynasty lasted for about one hundred years. The last Sunga king was Devabhuti. He was killed by his own minister Vasudeva Kanva. Vasudeva established the rule of Kanva dynasty in Magadha.

Importance of the Sunga Period

The Sungas played an important role in defending the Gangetic Valley from the encroachments of the Bactrian Greeks. Pushyamitra, and then his successors, revived Vedic religious practices and promoted Vaishnavism. Sanskrit gradually gained ascendancy and became the court language.

Patanjali, the second grammarian in Sanskrit, was patronized by Pushyamitra.

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